

Get Organised Firm Manager Access Content:

1. CA Capacity Planner

This section provides the CA Firm Capacity Planner model and supporting tutorial videos. The tools are designed as scenario models—not analytical reports—to help firms optimize team structure, price jobs, and transition into advisory services.

This material is for Firm/Practice owners only and is of an intermediate complexity level.

1. Base Capacity & Job Estimation Sheet

This template allows you to define baseline assumptions about how long jobs take, who performs them, and the resulting costs based on team size and hourly rates.

- **Benefits:** It dynamically calculates job costs and highlights skill deficiencies by linking staff levels (e.g., Junior, Senior, Equity Partner) to specific tasks and charge-out rates. It also allows you to align past known fees with projected assumptions to ground your model in reality.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Owners gain instant visibility into whether they have enough people to complete the work. It clearly reveals when highly-paid senior staff are forced to do lower-level tasks because of a deficiency in junior team members.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Advisors can use this to visually map out different fee ranges and client service categories (e.g., Growth, Protect, Transition), making it easier to discuss optimal team deployment.
- **Who it is suitable for:** Any professional service firm looking to understand their true baseline capacity, validate chargeable targets, or diagnose why staff feel overworked despite appearing to have enough overall time.

2. Scenario Versioning & Management Sheet

Rather than juggling multiple spreadsheet files, this model utilizes native version history to track different organizational states (e.g., "Base Scenario" vs. "Under a thousand clients").

- **Benefits:** You can save a scenario, alter specific variables (highlighted in blue cells), and effortlessly restore previous versions to compare outcomes. It also features customizable views, allowing you to hide unused partner rows or specific dashboard tabs if you have a smaller partnership.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It provides a sandbox to safely test structural changes without losing original data. Owners can adjust the number of periods for mid-year tracking to ensure volatility graphs and capacity ranges calculate correctly.

- **How it helps the advisor:** It allows for highly focused data entry by using a "filter range" so each partner only sees their specific clients while inputting fees.
- **Who it is suitable for:** Firms with varying partnership sizes (under six partners) who want to aggressively model "what-if" scenarios without creating disorganized file clusters.

3. Client Trimming & Advisory Transition Sheet

This scenario answers the age-old question: *"We want to get into advisory, but we don't have the time."* It models the financial and capacity impact of dropping a specific lower-tier percentage of the client base.

- **Benefits:** It calculates exactly how many clients you need to drop (e.g., the bottom 10%), the precise fee loss, and the exact amount of hours freed up. It then allows you to reallocate those recovered hours into higher-margin advisory roles.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It transitions "dropping clients" from a scary concept to a mathematically sound business strategy. Owners can see that reallocating time can actually increase total available hours, reduce team stress, and significantly boost bottom-line profits.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It frames the advisory transition around three pillars: *Capacity* (freed up by dropping clients), *Capability* (having the templates and skills ready), and *Opportunity* (identifying the larger clients willing to engage).
- **Who it is suitable for:** Firms that are trapped in a high-volume compliance cycle, experiencing margin erosion due to senior staff doing junior work, and looking to pivot to higher-value advisory services.

Step-by-Step Methods for Practical Application

Step 1: Configure Your Base Firm Layout Start by hiding any unused partner rows and unnecessary dashboards if your firm has fewer than six partners. Use the filter range to allow individual partners to cleanly input their client fee data.

Step 2: Establish Realistic Job Assumptions Determine how many hours an average, small, and large job takes, and select which team member performs each task from a dropdown menu. If your family group clients distort compliance statistics, override the total client count with the "actual number of returns filed" to ensure compliance time is accurate.

Step 3: Baseline Your Revenue Enter your past known fees and apply seasonal adjustments. Remember that this model assumes "perfect world" scenarios, so adding seasonal adjustments brings the adjusted capacity into a realistic ballpark. If you are mid-year, adjust the period tracker (e.g., change to 10 periods) to keep your actual vs. planned tracking accurate.

Step 4: Identify Skill Deficiencies Review the skill levels tab. Look for bottlenecks where upper-level team members have excess capacity, but lower-level tiers do not. This is the primary indicator that highly-paid staff are stepping down to do lower-rate jobs, which halves your effective charge-out rate.

Step 5: Model an Advisory Transition Scenario Save your current state using "File > Version History". Go to the client trimming section and select a percentage of bottom-tier clients to drop. Reallocate the newly available hours by adjusting the advisory percentage for partners, associates, and senior managers. Compare the resulting hours and potential fee increases against your base version.

Common Q&A

Q1: Is the Capacity Planner going to give me perfectly accurate historical reports?

No, this is specifically a *scenario model*, not an analytical report. While fee spread data is accurate, the core value lies in projecting assumptions and modeling future "what-if" scenarios.

Q2: What if we have multiple entities inside a single family group?

Because the model calculates based on total client count, multi-entity groups can skew the numbers. You can correct this by saving a new scenario and manually overriding the client count to reflect your *actual number of returns filed*.

Q3: We have a lot of partners and staff adding data; how do we keep it organized?

Use the filter range on the fee spread input page. A partner can clear the filter, select themselves, input only their data without scrolling through the whole firm, and then select all when finished.

Q4: Do I need to make a copy of the spreadsheet every time I want to test a new business model?

No. You can run everything in one place using the native Version History. Simply name your version (e.g., "Base Scenario" or "Trimmed Base"), make your changes (highlighted in blue), and use the restore function to easily toggle between different models.

Q5: Why is my senior team so stressed when the planner says we have enough total hours?

This usually indicates an imbalance in your skill levels. If you lack lower-level team members, upper-level staff must abandon high-value work to fill the gap, creating stress and destroying your charge-out efficiency.

Q6: We want to do advisory work, but we simply don't have the time. How does this tool help?

You can use the model to calculate the exact impact of dropping a specific percentage of your smallest clients. The tool will show you exactly how many hours are freed up, which you can then computationally reallocate to high-margin advisory work, often resulting in higher profits with fewer total working hours.

2. CA Firm Strategy

The CA Firm Strategy is designed to take an accounting or advisory firm from disorganized operational chaos to a structured, highly profitable advisory practice. The framework guides you through five sequential phases: Planning, Packaging, Coaching, Sales, and Delivery.

This material is for Firm/Practice owners only and is of an entry complexity level.

2.1. Capacity Planner & Target Models (My Fee Growth Model / Plan)

- Benefits: These calculators define the precise logistics of delivering advisory services while maintaining compliance. They reveal growth opportunities and define "time budgets" for the team based on client base size and skills.
- How it helps the Advisor: The *My Fee Growth Plan* helps advisors define target clients, niche service offers, and marketing statements, making them more confident in their engagement tasks. The *Team Advisory Targets* table clearly summarizes fee targets, client focus, and time expectations, removing ambiguity.

- How it helps the Business Owner: Ensures that clients are accurately categorized (Growth, Maintain, Service) so they receive the appropriate level of dedicated time and resources.
- Suitable for: Firm leaders mapping total capacity, and individual advisors (with full or shared autonomy) tasked with growing a fee base.

2.2. Team Training O.S. & Coaching Progress Plan

- Benefits: Defines the functional skills team members need to improve and tailors the coaching content to the team's experience and budget.
- How it helps the Advisor: By scheduling learning on a "work sprint" basis, it structures sessions around peak workflow commitments, preventing task avoidance during busy compliance periods.
- How it helps the Business Owner: Ensures the professionals advising them are undergoing continuous, structured improvement.
- Suitable for: Firm Managers, Internal Coaches, and all team members.

2.3. Growth Curve Checklist

- Benefits: Aligns the firm's strategic service offerings directly with the age and developmental stage of the client's business.
- How it helps the Advisor: Acts as a roadmap to unlock cross-selling potential. It empowers the advisor to "push" relevant service solutions (e.g., succession planning for mature businesses) into the client's service plan.
- How it helps the Business Owner: Ensures the advice they receive is contextually relevant to their current position (e.g., Design, Launch, Growth, Maturity).
- Suitable for: All client-facing advisors.

2.4. Strategic Evaluation Frameworks (Tech Review & Offshoring Review)

- Benefits: Provides structured ways to make difficult firm decisions without emotion. The *Technology Review* utilizes the Everett Rogers Diffusion of Innovation Theory and Porter's 5 Forces to evaluate tech and AI. The *Offshoring Review* utilizes Edward De Bono's 6 Hats framework to remove confirmation bias.
- How it helps the Advisor/Firm Manager: Prevents "shiny object syndrome" with technology and ensures a balanced exploration of offshoring pros and cons.
- Suitable for: The Partner Group and Firm Directors.

2.5. Contrast Models (FM Expectations and FM Stages)

- Benefits: Often described as the best "bang for buck" planning tools, these tables map out the interrelatedness of the owners' aspirations and the sequential business development objectives required to achieve them.
- Suitable for: Partners, Directors, and Firm Managers defining their "End Game".

2.6. Tracking & Accountability Software (Global Actions Report & CPD Log)

- Benefits: Centralizes accountability. The *Global Actions Report* summarizes all actions promised to clients, and the *CPD Log* tracks all learning.
 - How it helps the Advisor: Automates reminders so nothing is forgotten post-meeting.
 - How it helps the Business Owner: Translates advice into real-world action, providing evidence of progress and effectiveness "in the field".
 - Suitable for: Firm Management tracking performance, and Advisors tracking their daily tasks.
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Step-by-Step Practical Implementation

To roll this framework out effectively, follow the 5-step Advisor-e Architecture:

- **Step 1: Planning (Assess & Categorize)**
 - Compile your family-grouped accounts into the Capacity Planner.
 - Categorize your clients into *Growth*, *Maintain*, and *Service* tiers based on their fee potential and importance.
 - Use the Strategic Services Summary and Internal Functions Summary to assign "champions" to specific service lines and operational duties.
- **Step 2: Packaging (Align Services)**
 - Review the Growth Curve Checklist to brainstorm and align your service offers with the different lifecycle stages of your clients.
 - Use the Advisory Pricing Model to structure different rates for preparation, travel, and delivery.
- **Step 3: Coaching (Train the Team)**
 - Ensure advisors complete the My Fee Growth Model to set their personal conversion assumptions.
 - Conduct internal training using Team AI (Familiarity) Tasks to teach the team how to prompt AI and use basic automation. Guide them to track their learning in the CPD Table.

- **Step 4: Sales (Engage the Client)**

- Utilize EOY (End of Year) meetings and Revenue Model meetings to develop deliberate, repeatable discovery processes.
- Record the client's position on the Growth Curve to flush out long-term vision and short-term concerns.

- **Step 5: Delivery (Track & Refine)**

- Use the Dashboard / Volatility Report in your service delivery to easily explain financial performance to clients.
- Utilize the Global Actions Report and Advisor Action Plan to set automated reminders for client commitments, ensuring tasks are completed and measurable outcomes are achieved.

Common Q&A

Q1: How do we objectively evaluate implementing AI or new software?

Answer: Utilize the Technology Review document. It uses the Everett Rogers Diffusion of Innovation theory to determine your adoption appetite, and applies Porter's 5 Forces to analyze expectations and market pressures before adopting AI.

Q2: We are divided on whether to use offshore staff. How do we resolve this?

Answer: Use the Offshoring Review template, which utilizes Edward De Bono's 6 Hats Framework. This allows the partner group to separate facts (White Hat), emotions (Red Hat), risks (Black Hat), and benefits (Yellow Hat) without arguments or confirmation bias.

Q3: How do we prevent 'Service' level clients from consuming our capacity?

Answer: Adhere strictly to the Client Service Standards. Ensure that 'Growth' and 'Maintain' clients receive priority. For 'Service' clients, provide automated or scalable touchpoints (like Dashboard reports and templates) but place them at the back of the queue when workflow is compressed.

Q4: Do we use the exact same improvement plan for all staff members?

Answer: No. Use the My Fee Growth Plan for advisors responsible for expanding the firm's client base and generating revenue. For internal staff or team members not required to grow fees, use the My Improvement Plan to guide their internal performance reviews.

Q5: How do we ensure our advisory team actually completes their required training?

Answer: Use the Coaching Progress Plan to schedule learning in "work sprints" that respect peak workflow. Pair this with the CPD Table to track hours, and prioritize their "Weekly Golden Hr" for strategic learning above compliance deliveries.

3. Leadership

This section provides the core frameworks used to evaluate, onboard, and manage partners and directors. By integrating pathway guidelines, psychological profiling, and rigorous accountability metrics, these tools ensure that professional service firms maintain high standards of governance, performance, and culture.

This material is for Firm/Practice owners only and is of an advanced complexity level.

3.1. Directorship Pathway Guidelines (Templates 1 & 2)

Benefits: The Directorship Pathway templates provide a transparent, objective, and structured 5-year roadmap for an individual to transition into a partnership role. It removes ambiguity from the promotion process by establishing strict benchmarks for experience, character, and core competencies.

How it helps the Business Owner: Business owners benefit from predictable succession planning and risk mitigation. The framework ensures that incoming partners are culturally aligned, have a proven track record (such as managing \$250k in fees and generating \$125k in organic growth), and are financially responsible. It protects the firm by requiring new partners to have a family trust, be insurable, and maintain pristine personal financial affairs.

How it helps the Advisor: For advisors or assessing partners, these templates serve as a comprehensive evaluation rubric. The Competency Assessment Framework allows advisors to rank candidates on a 1 to 5 scale (from "Needs serious attention" to "Competent to coach others effectively") across critical areas like financial management, workflow scheduling, and delegating.

Who it is suitable for: These templates are ideal for professional service firms, accounting practices, and mid-sized businesses looking to cultivate internal talent for equity partnerships or directorship roles.

3.2. Enneagram-Based Employment Questions Framework

Benefits: This framework goes beyond standard technical interviews by identifying the deep-seated psychological motivations, stress triggers, and social preferences of candidates based on the 9 Enneagram types. It categorizes individuals into broader work styles, such as Soloists, Initiators, and Cooperators.

How it helps the Business Owner: Owners can use this to strategically build balanced teams and prevent cultural friction. By understanding whether a candidate is an "Achiever" driven by recognition or a "Peacemaker" avoiding conflict, the owner can align roles with natural strengths and anticipate how individuals will react under pressure.

How it helps the Advisor: It provides advisors and HR professionals with highly targeted behavioral interview questions. Instead of generic queries, an advisor can ask an "Investigator (Type 5)" how they cope when they know others are wrong, or ask a "Challenger (Type 8)" how they control sarcasm when faced with incompetence. This uncovers the candidate's self-awareness and emotional intelligence.

Who it is suitable for: Hiring managers, executive coaches, and advisors conducting advanced vetting for leadership, management, or highly collaborative team roles.

3.3. Partner Accountability & Conduct Framework

Benefits: This template establishes a robust governance structure through a highly detailed "Conduct & Effect" matrix and a Code of Conduct. It specifically identifies "Boardroom Manipulation Tactics" (like the "Taxi Driver mentality" or "The Assassin") and links behavioral or performance failures directly to financial consequences.

How it helps the Business Owner: It protects the firm's profitability and integrity. The Demerit Points Table objectively ties infractions to profit share entitlement (e.g., accumulating 20 points results in immediate resignation and forfeiture of the client base). Conversely, it incentivizes growth through a Bonus Points System (e.g., an extra **12k bonus for generating** >100k in new client fees).

How it helps the Advisor: It equips advisors and managing partners with a mechanism to manage underperformance or toxic behavior without relying purely on subjective feelings. Tools like the "Yellow Card System" provide structured warnings with expected response times ranging from 24 hours to 90 days. Furthermore, it allows advisors to evaluate partners based on their operational focus as "Finders, Minders, or Grinders".

Who it is suitable for: Existing boards of directors, established partnerships, or executive teams that require strict governance, conflict resolution tools, or formal performance management.

Step-by-Step Implementation Method

Step 1: Define the Pathway Criteria When identifying a 'Partner in Pathway' (P.I.P), allocate an Assessment Partner to them. Introduce the candidate to the **Directorship Pathway 1** guidelines so they understand the 5-year timeline, expected CPD hours, and the requirement to submit at least two formal white papers.

Step 2: Conduct Behavioral and Psychological Vetting During the associate phase, utilize the **Enneagram-Based Employment Questions**. Identify the candidate's core type. Use the targeted questions to evaluate how they handle conflict, prioritize tasks under pressure, and engage in teamwork. Ensure they have the self-awareness required for leadership.

Step 3: Execute the Competency Assessment Use the grid in **Directorship Pathway 2** to conduct a 360-degree review. Have the candidate rate themselves from 1 to 5 on competencies like "Secure Profitable Engagements" and "Chair a formal directors meeting", and compare this against the average ratings from existing partners.

Step 4: Establish Rules of Engagement and Accountability Once accepted as a partner, immediately integrate them into the **Partner Accountability** framework. Have them sign the Code of Conduct. Ensure they understand the definitions of Gross Negligence versus Mistake, and how the Demerit and Bonus Points systems impact their profit share.

Step 5: Ongoing Monitoring and Course Correction Regularly assess partner performance using the Finder/Minder/Grinder matrix. If a partner displays disruptive behavior (e.g., "The Bully & The Donkey" boardroom tactics), issue a **Yellow Card** to put them 'on notice' with a specific timeline (e.g., 24 hours or 7 days) to correct the behavior before demerits are applied.

Common Q&A

1. How long does the pathway to becoming a partner typically take?

The maximum 'Pathway Period' is five years. After this, the individual is either assessed as successful and commences sharing equity/risk, or they are 'exited' as terminally unsuitable.

2. How is a candidate's readiness objectively scored?

The Competency Assessment Framework uses a 1 to 5 rating scale ranging from "Needs serious attention" (1) to "Competent to coach others effectively" (5). This is applied across operational, financial, and managerial competencies.

3. What happens if a partner intentionally sabotages an initiative or acts unethically?

The Partner Accountability framework handles this via the Demerit Points Table and the Conduct Matrix. For instance, "Machiavellian" or "Gross Negligence" behaviors carry heavy demerit points. Accumulating 20 points in 12 months results in immediate resignation and trade restrictions.

4. How does the Enneagram framework improve the interview process?

Instead of asking generic questions, the Enneagram framework targets the specific weaknesses and stress responses of 9 distinct personality types. For example, asking a Type 7 (Enthusiast) how they organize themselves when faced with multiple tasks addresses their natural tendency to become scattered.

5. What is the "Yellow Card" system?

It is an interim warning system used to notify a director that their behavior is unacceptable and they are 'on notice.' It requires a serious attempt to improve within agreed response time guidelines (ranging from Immediate/24 hours to Normal/90 days).

6. How are partners evaluated on their business development versus technical work?

The framework categorizes working IN and ON the business through three profiles: Finder (securing new clients), Minder (maintaining existing relations), and Grinder (completing technical service delivery). Performance is ranked based on achieving specific targets within these roles.

4. Firm Board Pack

Implementing a robust governance framework is essential for accounting firm owners to move from working *in* the business to strategically directing it. By practicing top-tier governance habits using these specific tools, firm owners protect their assets, ensure logical decision-making, and create a scalable, professionally managed enterprise.

This material is for Firm/Practice owners only and is of an intermediate complexity level.

4.1. Board Agendas & Meeting Minutes (Master Agenda, BoardPack Agenda, Meeting Minutes)

- **Benefits:** These templates transition a casual business chat into a structured, accountable board meeting. They provide rigid time allocations, enforce the review of financial KPIs,

capture "what's gone well/less well," and mandate clear takeaways and conflict of interest declarations.

- **How it helps the Business Owner:** Ensures meetings stay on track, legally records decisions, and holds directors accountable to time and previously assigned action items.
- **How it helps the Advisor:** Gives the advisor a standardized environment to deliver guidance, track progress, and formally record their professional input.
- **Suitable For:** Any firm size implementing monthly or quarterly board or advisory board meetings.

4.2. Annual Board Plan & Document Tracker (Annual Plan, Boardpack Table)

- **Benefits:** The Annual Plan maps out 12 months of specific strategic focuses (e.g., Strategic Scenario Planning in Feb, CEO Performance Review in May, Internal Business Culture Review in July). The Boardpack Table ensures compliance by requiring directors to sign off that they have "Read and Understood" required reading, financials, and major correspondence before the meeting begins.
- **How it helps the Business Owner:** Prevents the board from getting bogged down in reactive, day-to-day issues by guaranteeing that crucial high-level topics are addressed systematically throughout the year.
- **How it helps the Advisor:** Allows the advisor to prepare focused, thematic advisory sessions well in advance.
- **Suitable For:** Maturing firms that need to transition from ad-hoc planning to an institutionalized annual governance rhythm.

4.3. Strategic Proposals (Board White Paper)

- **Benefits:** This template standardizes how new ideas or major purchases are pitched to the board. It requires an Executive Summary, Historical Context, Suggested Solution, Measurable Benefits, and an analysis of alternative solutions.
- **How it helps the Business Owner:** Removes emotional "gut-feeling" pitches from the boardroom. It forces thorough research and clear business cases before capital is committed.
- **How it helps the Advisor:** Provides a clear framework for the advisor to draft or review strategic expansion plans (like opening a new branch or buying software).
- **Suitable For:** Firms evaluating major expenditures, mergers, new market entries, or significant internal changes.

4.4. Quality Decisions & Risk Management (Risk Mgt Cover, Quality Decisions)

- **Benefits:** These resources tackle the psychology and mechanics of business leadership. The Risk Matrix categorizes threats by probability and consequence to determine if risks should be Accepted, Avoided, Reduced, or Transferred. The Quality Decisions material educates the board on "Psyche Errors" (like Optimism Bias, Confirmation Bias, and Complacency) linked to different layers of business complexity. It also introduces a "Decision Workpaper" to capture the logic, counter-arguments, and early failure indicators for chosen solutions.
- **How it helps the Business Owner:** Protects the owner from their own cognitive biases and helps distinguish between true causation and mere correlation when analyzing data.
- **How it helps the Advisor:** Empowers the advisor to challenge the owner's assumptions safely using established frameworks like the "5 Whys", W. Edward Deming's Theory of Volatility, and Double-Blind testing.
- **Suitable For:** High-growth firms, firms in transition/succession, or boards prone to emotional or highly biased decision-making.

4.5. Formal Actions (Resolutions)

- **Benefits:** Provides the exact legal templates required to authorize major financial or operational shifts—such as purchasing a private jet, paying dividends, raising capital, or launching a new company.
- **How it helps the Business Owner:** Creates a legally binding, auditable trail of unanimous or majority director votes, protecting the corporate veil.
- **How it helps the Advisor:** Ensures the firm's major moves are executed with strict legal and financial compliance.
- **Suitable For:** Incorporated firms executing binding financial commitments or structural changes.

Step-by-Step Practical Implementation

- **Step 1: Set the Annual Rhythm:** Start with the **Annual Board Plan**. Plot out the next 12 months, assigning one core strategic theme to each month (e.g., Technology Policy review in September, Budgets in April).
- **Step 2: Prepare the Board Pack:** Two weeks before a meeting, distribute the **Boardpack Agenda**, previous **Meeting Minutes**, and any required **Board White Papers** for upcoming decisions.

- **Step 3: Enforce Preparation:** Use the **Boardpack Table** to require all attendees to check the "Read and Understood" box for all provided materials before they are allowed to debate.
- **Step 4: Conduct the Meeting Safely:** Follow the agenda strictly. When complex problems arise, use the **Quality Decisions** frameworks. Document the problem, alternative solutions, the logic supporting the chosen route, and establish "early failure indicators" using the Decision Workpaper.
- **Step 5: Record and Formalize:** During the meeting, ensure the scribe actively fills out the **Meeting Minutes**. If a major financial decision is made (e.g., raising capital), immediately draft and have all directors sign a formal **Resolution**.
- **Step 6: Ongoing Risk Review:** Make the **Risk Mgt Cover** a living document. Continually brainstorm new risks, evaluate them on the probability/consequence matrix, and update the action plan for risk mitigation.

Common Q&A

Q: How do we prevent our board meetings from just becoming operational status updates?

A: Utilize the *Annual Board Plan* and the *Boardpack Agenda*. The annual plan forces the board to look at specific high-level topics (like Director Succession or Board Performance Reviews) at scheduled times of the year. The agenda ring-fences time for "General Business" and prioritizes strategic "Scheduled Items".

Q: What is a "Decision Workpaper" and why should our firm use it?

A: A Decision Workpaper is a formal document that tracks the life cycle of a choice. It records the problem, all considered solutions, the pros/cons, the specific logic for the selected solution, the

counter-arguments, and milestone "Early Failure Indicators". It builds a habit of quality decision-making by tracking *why* a decision was made so you can learn from it later.

Q: Our board often gets overly excited about new opportunities. How can we slow down and evaluate things objectively?

A: Require a *Board White Paper* for any major new initiative. This forces the proposer to clearly document the historical context, analyze alternative solutions, present feasibility data, and assess the risk of failure *before* the board votes. You should also review the "Optimism Bias" framework to understand how the desire for future rewards can cause directors to ignore negative information.

Q: How do we properly classify and manage business risks?

A: Use the *Risk Tactics Matrix*. First, assess risks by their Probability (likelihood) and Consequence (loss severity). Based on where they fall on the matrix, apply one of four strategies: Accept (undertake as is), Avoid (cease the activity), Reduce (limit exposure), or Transfer (insure or share via third party).

Q: We had a spike in sales last month after changing our marketing. How do we know if our marketing actually worked?

A: You must apply the rules of *Interpreting Data Correctly* to determine if the relationship is Causation, Correlation, or Coincidence. Causation requires evidence of direct influence. Just because sales went up when marketing changed does not mean marketing *caused* it—it must be tested against independent and dependent variables, potentially using Double-Blind testing methods to ensure validity.

Q: What is the purpose of the Boardpack Table with the checkboxes?

A: The *Boardpack Table* tracks which directors have actually received, read, and understood the meeting materials (Agendas, CEO Reports, Financials, Major Correspondence). This prevents time-wasting in the boardroom and ensures all directors are operating with the same factual baseline.

5. Coaching & Culture

This section provides a comprehensive suite of development and training frameworks for business advisors, focusing on transitioning from traditional methods to a flipped learning model.

This material is for Firm/Practice owners only and is of a medium complexity level.

5.1. Flipping The Training Process (Flipping the Learning)

- **Benefits:** This template shifts the firm away from traditional, generic learning paths by utilizing a technology-enabled closed feedback loop. It ensures training is strictly driven by real client needs.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It ensures that the advisory firm's time and resources are explicitly dedicated to learning how to solve the exact, common problems the business owner is currently facing.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It connects their education directly to immediate client outcomes. It removes ambiguity by clarifying exactly "who (in our team) needs to learn what & by when" to deliver the necessary success actions.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** Practice partners, training managers, and HR leaders responsible for mapping out the internal training curriculum and tracking progress.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Identify the Problem:** Start by asking, "What are the common problems we see our clients dealing with?"
2. **Work Backwards:** Determine the "Common Success Actions"—the specific actions that will help 'move the needle' for the client in that situation.
3. **Align Internal Operations:** Align internal divisions and develop or edit templates to support client education and problem-solving logic.
4. **Assign Tasks:** Ask "Who needs to learn what, and over what timeframe?" and import these tasks into a timeline/reminder platform.
5. **Monitor & Refine:** Monitor completed tasks and filter reports to find 'Common Failures,' utilizing this data to continuously improve the feedback loop.

5.1.1. Advisor Case Study Prep

- **Benefits:** This template provides a highly structured checklist and workflow for preparing and running internal client review sessions.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It ensures that their business issues are systematically analyzed against a structured framework (Planning & Data, Sales & Marketing, People & Process) and that any new ideas are tested in a revenue model before real-world business changes are made.

- **How it helps the advisor:** It gives the advisor a definitive roadmap for preparation. It outlines exactly what they need to do prior to a meeting (the Golden Hr prep), and provides a structured way to capture ideas and objections from peers (in the Platinum Hr) before facing the client.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** Advisors who are actively preparing for a client review, or those ready to present a client case study to their internal team for feedback.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Load & Select:** Create the business entity in Advisor-e and select the most industry-appropriate revenue model.
2. **Structure the Plan:** Open the Client Service Plan and add regular content like dashboard reports, revenue models, and agenda notes.
3. **Analyze Issues:** Think of the client's issues against the "Get Organised, Get the Job, Do the Job" framework to see which domain needs the most help.
4. **Review Content:** Select a supporting template, watch the tutorial video, note any desired changes, and log the time in your CPD log.
5. **Run the Session:** Start by introducing the client financials and observed trends, explain your service offer, open the floor to peers for ideas, and capture those ideas in the client service plan while in session.

5.1.2. Team Training O.S

- **Benefits:** This template provides clear "Field Outcome Statements" that define the responsibilities, boundaries, and expected coaching requirements across different advisory tiers.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Ensures the client is matched with an advisor functioning at the correct level of expertise—whether that is software training or facilitating complex, conflict-based business solutions.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It sets crystal clear career expectations. An 'Associate Advisor' knows they are expected to manage accounts proactively but aren't required to hunt for new prospects. A 'Strategic Advisor' knows exactly what skills they need to master to become a future 'Partnership Option'.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** Management tracking the "Professional's Journey," and team members looking to understand their specific role boundaries and upward progression paths.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Assess Capability:** Identify the team member's baseline skills (e.g., intimate knowledge of software and tools).
2. **Assign Role & Boundaries:** Map them to the corresponding tier (e.g., Advisory Support) and enforce boundaries (e.g., they will not be required to conduct meetings in isolation).
3. **Target Coaching:** Provide coaching specific to that role via the Advisor-e Support framework (e.g., software orientation for Support roles; advanced facilitation and consultative sales for Strategic roles).
4. **Advance Responsibilities:** As skills increase, transition responsibilities (e.g., moving a Support member to Support + where they run educational client meetings as a testing ground for the Associate role).

5.1.3. Building Learning Culture

- **Benefits:** This template establishes the framework for a transparent environment of constant improvement, providing the "rules of engagement" for a safe, non-judgmental team culture.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It guarantees that the advice they receive is not isolated; it is the product of an entire advisory team that constantly validates their field intelligence through structured group feedback.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It creates a "Social Contract" that makes them feel safe. It removes the fear of critique by stating that "nobody's perfect" and provides structured scripts so they can share vulnerabilities and receive peer feedback without taking offense.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** The entire organization, as a visible learning culture requires that "EVERYBODY participates... no exceptions".

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Independent Prep:** A team member begins in their "Golden Hr," working on their own to force active participation in their personal learning and development.
2. **Group Transition:** The member transitions to the "Platinum Hr" session, which is dedicated specifically to team feedback and group problem solving.
3. **Present the Case:** The member uses the structured "Platinum Case Study Format" to present the client's financials, observed trends, and service offer to the team.
4. **Validate via Feedback:** The rest of the team uses the VISIBLE Learning Culture Feedback Model to explicitly state what "stands out," what they want to clarify/challenge, and to validate the presenter.
5. **Review Real-World Output:** After dealing with the client, the member returns to the next Platinum Hr to run a 'Review' session detailing what went well, what went less well, and future actions.

Common Q&A

Q1: What is the primary difference between a Golden Hr and a Platinum Hr? A: The Golden Hr is designated for a team member to do on their own, forcing them to take an active part in their personal learning. The Platinum Hr is designed specifically for team member feedback and group "problem solving".

Q2: What is the core characteristic of a learning culture? A: A learning culture is an environment of constant improvement that is completely transparent and free from judgment. It relies on the inclusion of everybody without exception.

Q3: How does the "Flipping the Training Process" differ from a Traditional Learning Path? A: A traditional path starts by determining what the firm wants to deliver. The flipped process starts by asking what common problems clients are facing, and then works backwards to figure out what internal training is required to solve those specific issues.

Q4: Will an "Advisory Support +" team member need to find and secure new clients? A: No. While they may run specific educational client meetings, they are guided by a partner regarding who they deal with and are not required to scope or secure engagements.

Q5: What are the expectations of a "Strategic Advisor"? A: They must be able to approach new prospects, build networks, conduct total needs client discovery, scope and price engagements, manage 'A' client accounts, and act as future "Partnership Options".

Q6: Why is structured feedback so important in this framework? A: It ensures that field intelligence and group learning are validated, not left to chance. It builds contextual awareness while maintaining a feeling of safety and inclusion.

5.2. Coaching Progress Plan

Benefits: A comprehensive spreadsheet tracking a 60-session coaching curriculum, including pricing models, hours, and specific skills training. **How it helps the Business Owner:** Provides measurable ROI on coaching by clearly mapping topics, planned attendees, and delivery hours against specific field outcomes. **How it helps the Advisor:** Gives a predictable, structured pathway to build their skillset, transitioning from technical software usage to advanced soft skills (e.g., sales framing, COI development). **Suitable for:** Practice managers and advisors managing long-term professional development.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Review the pricing model and total coaching hours allocated for the period.

2. Identify the next chronological session (e.g., Framing 1A) and note the specific skill outcome.
3. Complete the minimum required preparation (e.g., watching assigned tutorial videos).
4. Conduct the coaching session with the designated team members.
5. Measure success against the stated field objective before moving to the next module.

5.3. FM Hiring Winners

Benefits: A strategic slide deck covering recruitment theory, leadership alignment, candidate screening, and orientation frameworks. How it helps the Business Owner: Prevents the extreme financial cost of a bad hire by defining the firm's leadership style, flushing out appropriate talent, and testing applicants rigorously. How it helps the Advisor/New Hire: Provides a structured "Buddy System" during orientation that validates their career choice and offers safe, immediate tasks. Suitable for: Leadership teams and HR managers actively preparing to recruit and onboard new staff.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Define your personal leadership style (e.g., Creative Abrasion vs. Creative Resolution).
2. Assess role requirements against the organizational structure to see if a full-time hire is genuinely needed.
3. Flush out talent by placing creative job ads in non-traditional locations.
4. Grade applicants through a 3-stage process: Feel (Meeting 1), Know (Meeting 2), and Test (Meeting 3).
5. Implement the structured AM/PM orientation table for the new hire's first two days.

5.3.1. FM Leadership.1

Benefits: A questionnaire evaluating the fundamental alignment between a leader's personality and the business's cultural needs. How it helps the Business Owner: Ensures the leadership style being deployed is actually suited to the firm's specific industry (e.g., an accounting firm needing strict compliance vs. a creative design agency). How it helps the Advisor (Leader): Helps them identify the pros and cons of 'Creativity' vs. 'Discipline' cultures, preventing them from blindly mimicking leadership styles that don't fit their personality. Suitable for: Senior leadership teams defining the strategic operational culture of the firm.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. List the pros and cons of a 'Creativity' culture versus a 'Discipline' culture for your firm.
2. Identify what behavior your current leadership style attempts to reflect in others.
3. Document any specific individuals you have modeled your leadership style upon.

4. Analyze if your desired culture, industry needs, and personal traits are authentically aligned.

5.3.2. FM Leadership 2

Benefits: A self-reflection questionnaire challenging leaders to evaluate their inclusivity and response to disagreement. How it helps the Business Owner: Ensures leadership blind spots do not create a toxic environment that stifles diversity or silences valuable input from junior staff. How it helps the Advisor (Leader): Forces profound self-awareness, asking them if they value "being right" more than finding the best solution for the team. Suitable for: Existing partners, practice managers, and emerging leaders.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Rate your firm's business culture on a scale of 1 to 10.
2. Reflect on how actively you seek diversity when recruiting.
3. Assess how inclusive your meetings are (e.g., do you call on the "quiet ones at the back"?).
4. Evaluate if you demonstrate healthy respect for all team members regardless of position.
5. Honestly document how you cope when a team member disagrees with your opinion.
- 5.

5.3.3. FM Team 'CANOE' Review

Benefits: A 360-degree review spreadsheet measuring five observable personality traits: Conscientiousness, Agreeableness, Neuroticism, Openness, and Extraversion. How it helps the Business Owner: Collates team averages to highlight trait "gaps," ensuring future job advertisements seek complementary skills rather than cloning existing personalities. How it helps the Advisor: Builds emotional intelligence by comparing "How I see myself" directly against "How others see me." Suitable for: Whole teams undergoing synergy audits or managers preparing a hiring plan.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Allocate up to 5 colleagues to observe each team member privately.
2. Have each individual complete the self-assessment based on provided trait indicators.
3. Have the designated peers complete their observation assessments.
4. Collate the data into the "Team Summary" spreadsheet.
5. Analyze the combined averages to identify areas lacking team diversity.

5.3.4. Job Ad Assoc

Benefits: A pre-written job advertisement template designed to recruit an Associate Advisor. How it helps the Business Owner: Saves drafting time and clearly outlines the firm's specific expectations, including starting fee base targets (\$135,000) and allotted training hours. How it helps the Advisor (Applicant): Clearly defines the "partnership pathway," the exact size of the portfolio they will manage, and the structural support available. Suitable for: Hiring managers actively seeking to recruit ambitious mid-level accountants.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Customize the firm name and regional district details.
2. Adjust the starting fee base and client numbers to match internal capacity.
3. Publish the ad in targeted recruitment areas.
4. Request applicants submit a short video to demonstrate their communication skills.
5. Grade applicants against the stated partnership pathway criteria.
- 1.
- 6.

5.4. Paper Tower Model

Benefits: A financial spreadsheet calculator designed to measure the profit or loss of a team construction exercise. How it helps the Business Owner: Translates soft skills (team communication, planning) into hard financial metrics, vividly proving how inefficiency hurts the bottom line. How it helps the Advisor (Participant): Demonstrates firsthand how rushing into action without a plan leads to material waste and financial loss. Suitable for: Workshop facilitators running team-building and conflict resolution exercises.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Wait for the team to complete the physical tower build.
2. Input the exact number of minutes taken into the spreadsheet.
3. Input the number of paper batches drawn (\$2,000 cost per batch of 20).
4. Measure and input the final height of the tower in millimeters.
5. Review the auto-calculated final profit or loss figure and announce it to the group.

5.4.1. Paper Tower Review Questions

Benefits: A facilitator's debrief script that breaks down the psychology and dynamics observed during the Paper Tower exercise. How it helps the Business Owner: Translates a simple game into a profound business lesson, introducing the 9-step team process for managing future corporate projects. How it helps the Advisor (Participant): Exposes whether they rely on chaotic

"outcome-oriented" behavior or structured "process-driven" logic. Suitable for: Facilitators guiding the post-exercise reflection session.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Ask the group if their objective was accurately defined and if a financial calculation was done prior to building.
2. Read back exact, timestamped observations of what team members said during the exercise.
3. Ask the group if they were outcome-oriented or process-driven.
4. Reveal the 9-step team process (Appoint Chairperson, Determine SMART Objective, Brainstorm without assessment, etc.).
5. Facilitate a discussion on how this 9-step process can be applied to real work tasks.

5.4.2. Paper Tower Task Sheet

Benefits: The strict, formal rule sheet provided to participants outlining the constraints of the tower exercise. How it helps the Business Owner (Facilitator): Sets indisputable boundaries that create artificial pressure to test team dynamics safely. How it helps the Advisor (Participant): Forces the team to manage strict deadlines (30 minutes total) against the high cost of materials. Suitable for: Teams directly participating in the Paper Tower workshop.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Read the objective: Build a tower profitably based on materials, height, and time.
2. Receive the initial 100 sheets of paper.
3. Utilize the strict 20-minute planning phase (no prefabrication allowed).
4. Execute the build within the strict 10-minute construction phase.
5. Ensure the completed tower stands self-supported for at least one minute.

5.4.3. Spaghetti Tower Task Sheet

Benefits: An alternative team construction exercise focusing strictly on structural stability and height rather than financial profitability. How it helps the Business Owner (Facilitator): Tests the team's ability to prototype and communicate under pressure using highly fragile materials. How it helps the Advisor (Participant): Challenges their physical execution, creativity, and collaborative problem-solving skills. Suitable for: Teams needing an engaging icebreaker or physical communication test.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Review the rules: Build the tallest tower possible within 30 minutes.
2. Collect the exact resources: 20 sticks of spaghetti, tape, 1 meter of string, and 2 marshmallows.
3. Utilize the 20-minute preparation phase without prefabricating materials.

4. Construct the tower in the final 10 minutes, placing 1 complete marshmallow at the very top.
5. Ensure the structure stands self-supported for one minute before measuring.

5.4.4. Team Workshop Run Sheet

Benefits: A minute-by-minute logistical schedule dictating the flow of a comprehensive two-day team workshop. How it helps the Business Owner: Maximizes the ROI of taking staff offline by ensuring the event runs flawlessly on time without momentum loss. How it helps the Advisor (Facilitator): Removes the stress of event management by providing exact timings for content blocks, breaks, and daily reviews. Suitable for: Event facilitators and managers organizing internal firm retreats or training days.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Review the overarching schedule for Day 1 and Day 2.
2. Prepare content specifically to fit the designated 90-minute session blocks.
3. Adhere strictly to the designated start and finish times for morning tea and lunch breaks.
4. Execute the required 10-minute management reviews within the schedule.
5. Conclude each day strictly with the allocated 30-minute "Day Review" session.

5.5. Advisory PIP Template

Benefits: Formalizes a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) specifically tailored for advisory roles and software adoption. How it helps the Business Owner: Protects the firm against potential fee loss and toxic culture by strictly documenting underperformance and preventing vocal resistance from undermining the visible learning culture. How it helps the Advisor: Removes all ambiguity by stating exactly what their performance gap is, outlining specific behaviors to *start* and *stop* doing, and detailing the exact mentorship available. Suitable for: Team members failing to meet minimum pre/post-meeting portal expectations or resisting advisory engagement.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Document the exact data metric of failure (e.g., 30 assigned clients but only 14 portal entities created).
2. Clarify the firm's minimum expectations for loading financials and tagging post-meeting actions.

3. Define specific actions the employee must implement and behaviors they must cease immediately.
 4. Assign a specific partner or mentor for role-play and software support.
 5. Schedule strict review milestones (e.g., 30, 60, and 90 days).
-

Common Q&A

1. What is the difference between a "Golden Hr" and a "Platinum Hr"?

A: The Golden Hr is designed for an individual team member to prepare on their own (e.g., watching tutorials, loading clients into the portal), forcing them to take active ownership of their learning. The Platinum Hr is a collaborative group session designed specifically for team member presentations, receiving structured feedback, and group problem-solving.

2. What is the 9-step team process taught during the Tower exercises?

A: The 9-step process helps teams move from chaotic outcomes to process-driven logic. It requires teams to: 1. Appoint a Chairperson, 2. Appoint a Timekeeper/Scribe, 3. Determine a S.M.A.R.T objective, 4. Apportion time, 5. Brainstorm *without* assessment, 6. Assess options, 7. Eliminate/select the best option, 8. Allocate resources, and 9. Prepare and implement the action plan.

3. How should an interviewer handle an applicant who fails the 'Feel' stage of an interview?

A: If an applicant fails the Meeting 1 'Feel' stage (where you use open-ended questions to gauge traits) badly, you should stop the interview process there. If they don't do great but appear to have the right technical skills, you proceed to the Meeting 2 'Know' stage but bring in an alternative interviewer to help reduce your personal bias.

4. What is the purpose of using a 3rd person persona when approaching a Center of Influence (COI)?

A: When dealing with guarded prospects (like "Mr. Prickly"), using a 3rd person persona and the "Event, Cause, Effect" method allows you to discuss sensitive issues without asking the prospect to expose their own weaknesses. This allows them to "save face," lowers their defensive filters, and positions you as a credible problem solver rather than a salesperson.

5. How does 'Flipping the Learning' differ from traditional training?

A: Traditional training starts by determining what a manager wants to deliver, developing content, and having an advisor present it. "Flipping" the process uses a closed loop that starts by identifying common *client* problems. You then work backward to determine what the client needs to do, what the advisor needs to learn to facilitate that, and finally, track the tasks to find common failures to update the templates.

6. What is 'Creative Abrasion' in leadership?

A: Creative Abrasion is a leadership style found in highly innovative teams where healthy debate is expected and encouraged. Teams amplify their differences and clash ideas against each other to find better solutions. The fundamental rule for this to work is that when they debate, they strictly "play the ball and not the player," ensuring no personal attacks occur.

6. Group Coaching Tutorials

This section provides a comprehensive suite of development and training frameworks for various applications. Each session includes a presentation VIDEO that has 'break-out' sections designed to enhance attendee participation and team learning. Each session also has a support template to further understanding and discussion. In addition, each session is supported by a Coach Prep VIDEO and session run sheet.

The sessions are fun, interactive and quick to prepare for as a facilitator. Just turn on the video and hit 'pause' when it's time to discuss the breakout questions!

This material is for Firm/Practice owners only and is of a medium complexity level. These workshops are a perfect way to drive team collaboration and learning as you pursue a 'Visible Learning Culture'.

6.1. Coping With Disruption

Content Covered	Why
This session begins by defining a business culture & explaining why learning is a journey - not a destination.	The main theme of this session is to encourage EVERYONE on the team to take responsibility for developing a competitive advantage. It's about developing a culture of progression and honesty - perfection can come later!

The content now shifts to explaining the reticular activating system & how your (current) knowledge base attracts new knowledge. It introduces the concept of Global & Local recognition.	Fear of anything new can result in people withdrawing from the topic/issue. We need to encourage people to maintain awareness, develop scenarios, (avoid predictions) and develop actions that 'make good sense - no matter the outcome'.
We then explore the 3 coping styles postulated by the Enneagram Personality system.	The hardest part about coping (with anything) is the ability to 'catch yourself' falling into default mechanisms, and recognising the need to 'self guide internal dialogue' to enable better navigation of your emotions and physical response.
We shift our attention to taking practical steps towards skill development and technology adoption.	We need to develop specific actions to achieve a competitive advantage. This is where team members volunteer their thoughts and 'who wants to learn what' :)
Finally, we review the need to 'learn to fail'.	The art of giving and receiving feedback requires practice. The aim is to use templates to help remove the emotion from a topic, so defined action plans can be developed.

6.1.1. Coping With Disruption Coach Prep

Benefits of the Template

- How it helps the business owner: It helps build a visible learning culture that demonstrates intent, ensuring learning is a constant journey to develop skills that create a competitive advantage and can be on-charged to clients.
- How it helps the advisor: It helps the advisor recognize how the Reticular Activating System (R.A.S) limits their SWOT analysis, and teaches them to use feedback frameworks to learn how to fail without emotional blackmail.
- Who it may be suitable for: This template is suitable for internal coaches or leaders who are responsible for facilitating 1.5-hour breakout sessions for the team.

Step-by-Step Method in Practice

1. Prepare for the session by allowing at least 90 minutes to ensure there is enough time to run the 5 designated breakout sessions.
2. Use the provided time slots and breakout questions to guide the team; for example, discuss the pros and cons of a visible learning culture at the 05 min 35 sec mark.
3. Guide the team to brainstorm skills that clients will value, and specifically identify how technology adoption can become "how we do it here".

4. Have the team utilize the 90-day learning focus to note exactly how their new skills will benefit the client, themselves, and the firm.
5. Conclude the session by setting homework: defining "Who is doing What, When?" and planning a brief review to share war stories.

Common Q&A

1. Q: How long is the total training video run time? A: The total video run time is 34 mins 48 sec.
2. Q: Why is a Visible Learning Culture important? A: It demonstrates intent and ensures that learning is treated as an ongoing journey rather than a final destination.
3. Q: What is the impact of the Reticular Activating System (R.A.S)? A: The R.A.S acts as a selective filter that determines what you pay attention to, which can limit your SWOT analysis and recognition of change drivers.
4. Q: What makes a newly adopted skill beneficial to the business? A: It must relate to a competitive advantage that can be on-charged to clients, effectively creating a "3x win".
5. Q: Why is a framework needed for the "Learning to Fail" segment? A: Humility requires practice, and emotional blackmail doesn't work; frameworks remove emotion so you can give and receive feedback effectively.

6.1.2. Coping With Disruption Support

Benefits of the TemplateHow it helps the business owner: It fosters a healthy business culture that acts as a social contract making employees feel safe, ensuring that culture reflects leadership actions consistent with stated objectives.

- How it helps the advisor: It provides a Progressive Learning Path to help advisors move from acquiring information to mastery, and helps them identify their blind spots during an argument or crisis using Enneagram profiles.
- Who it may be suitable for: Tutorial attendees and team members needing visual aids to better understand learning psychology and their own coping mechanisms.

Step-by-Step Method in Practice

1. Review the definition of a healthy business culture as a social contract where people want to belong.
2. Follow the Progressive Learning Path by understanding that acquiring information via the 5 senses is only the first step; you must process it and associate it with past learnings.

3. Determine which Enneagram Harmonic Group you belong to: the Positive Outlook Group, the Competency Group, or the Intensity Group.
4. Identify your group's specific "Key Struggle" when facing conflict, disappointment, or unmet needs.
5. Use this information to spot your "blind spot" during a crisis to avoid costly, detached, or hurried responses.

Common Q&A

1. Q: What exactly IS a business culture? A: It is a collection of spoken and unspoken "permissions" about how a group behaves together.
2. Q: How do we properly process what we learn? A: Acquiring via our 5 senses is only one third of the process; we must then process what we've acquired and associate it with past learnings so we can recall it.
3. Q: How does the Positive Outlook Group handle conflict? A: Their first instinct is to reframe it, minimize it, or look for a silver lining, which means they can be dismissive of reality or "spiritually bypass" problems.
4. Q: How does the Competency Group manage high stress? A: They detach from their emotions and focus on the task at hand, which can make them appear cold, robotic, or disconnected from the human element.
5. Q: Why might the Intensity Group be seen as difficult in a crisis? A: Because they react emotionally and demand an authentic emotional reaction from others to feel heard; they want to address the "truth" instead of hearing a silver lining.

6.2. Structure Networking

Content Covered	Why
This session begins by understanding the difference between developing centres of influence vs structured networking.	The two approaches vary significantly in terms of time, skill and advisor confidence requirements. Knowing the key differences will allow advisors to choose a learning path that best suits them.

The content proceeds to explore the psychological blockages (barriers) that advisors must overcome when networking effectively.	Fear of anything new and challenging is natural; understanding the underlying contributors to the (individuals) fear is the first step in overcoming it.
We then explore the 'Advisor-e Relationship Staircase'.	This graphic makes it easy to relate the theories discussed and draw practical conclusions about how to identify the relationship stage and what's required to develop the relationship over time.
Our focus then shifts to 'how to avoid giving free business advice' during your 'coffee chat'.	The client's expectation and service conditioning means they're likely to associate the meeting to local/operational issues they're currently dealing with, which of course implies you (as their advisor) will be happy to help. We need to learn how to frame our time together towards more global issues, so we avoid giving away 'quick fixes and tips'.
Finally, we review the internal dialogue 'challenges' faced by advisors, when networking.	The accountant's business model is counter intuitive to positioning, networking and developing centres of influence. If we don't deal with the 'self talk' our advisors will keep finding reasons to delay these tactics.

6.2.1. Structured Networking Coach Prep

Benefits

- How it helps the business owner: It provides a structured approach to developing intentional relationships with their existing network, helping them move away from merely interrogating contacts to sharing and building true value.
- How it helps the advisor: It offers a comprehensive, timed agenda for a 90-minute coaching session, complete with specific breakout questions, time slots, and a framework for managing internal dialogues (e.g., resisting the urge to pitch).
- Who it may be suitable for: Advisors running group training sessions, team leaders, or coaches aiming to guide professionals on how to systematically improve their networking and relationship-building skills.

How to Use the Material in Practice (Step-by-Step)

1. Allocate Time: Schedule at least 90 minutes for the session, keeping in mind the video run time is roughly 40 minutes and 23 seconds.

2. Follow the Agenda: Progress through the five key sections: "Structured Networking vs Centre of Influence Development," "What blocks relations from building," "Chicken or Egg Getting started," "Avoiding Free Business Advice," and "Managing Your Internal Dialogue".
3. Facilitate Breakout Sessions: At the designated time slots (e.g., 4 min 13, 12 min 47), pause to ask the specific Breakout Questions provided, such as asking participants to list 3 clients they currently enjoy dealing with.
4. Capture Insights: Use the "Coaching Notes" section to record observations and feedback for each of the five core agenda topics.
5. Assign Homework: Conclude the session by assigning the suggested advisor homework: have them plan an approach to the 3 clients discussed, rehearse their topic, make contact to secure a coffee chat, and prepare to provide group feedback.

Common Q&A

- Q: What is the main difference between Structured Networking and developing Centres of Influence (COI)? A: Structured networking focuses on repeating behaviors you already know to position yourself with existing clients with intent, whereas developing COIs is specifically about gaining referrals.
- Q: How much time should be allowed per session? A: You should allow at least 90 minutes for the session to accommodate the 5 breakout sessions and fuel interaction.
- Q: How can I manage my internal dialogue during these networking situations? A: You can adopt specific mental frameworks, such as telling yourself, "I must resist the urge to pitch or secure the deal," or "I'm more than an accurate accountant - I must position on the value of me".
- Q: What tactic can be used to avoid giving free business advice during a coffee chat? A: You can merge the conversation from global business to global personal, discussing life after business, or as a last resort, draw the Growth Curve on a napkin.
- Q: What homework should participants complete after the session? A: They must plan their approach to the 3 clients they listed, rehearse their preferred topic if lacking confidence, secure a coffee chat, and provide group feedback afterwards.

6.2.2. Structured Networking Support

Benefits

- How it helps the business owner: It helps them understand the psychological drivers behind human interactions, allowing them to form better habits, read social situations effectively, and communicate with greater emotional intelligence.
- How it helps the advisor: It provides visual aids and deep psychological frameworks (such as the Jo-Hari Window and Freud's Psyche Structure) to analyze client communication styles, objectively grade the depth of client relationships via a staircase model, and intentionally plan communication.
- Who it may be suitable for: Professionals, consultants, and advisors who want to master the psychology of relationship building, understand social dynamics, and implement micro-habits for long-term networking success.

How to Use the Material in Practice (Step-by-Step)

1. Define Your Network: Categorize your contacts by differentiating between existing clients, Centres of Influence (who provide referrals), and Centres of Intelligence (who provide valuable information or mentorship).
2. Analyze Social Dynamics: Use the "Coded Behavior" framework to understand the situational norms (the "social codebook") of the environments you are networking in, ensuring you are encoding your behavior appropriately.
3. Assess Communication Styles: Evaluate yourself and your clients using the Jo-Hari Window to determine if someone is an Open Person (Ideal), Blind Person (Bull in a China Shop), Hidden Person (Interviewer), or Unknown Person (Turtle).
4. Grade the Relationship: Plot your current clients on the "Relationship Staircase" to visually determine where you stand (e.g., are you at the "Coffee Chat" stage or the "Dinner With Spouse" stage?).
5. Steer Conversations Strategically: Utilize the "Global & Local References" technique. Start with a Global perspective (e.g., industry-wide issues) to expand the permission boundary and reduce tension, then drop to Ground Level (Local reference) to ask how it affects their business specifically.
6. Implement Micro-Habits: Follow the 5 Steps to Building New Habits by identifying a Reason, finding a Trigger, establishing a Micro Habit, applying Effective Practice, and solidifying it with a Plan.

Common Q&A

- Q: What is the difference between networking and selling? A: Networking is selling yourself, whereas selling is selling your product or service.
- Q: What is "Coded Behavior"? A: It is behavior that follows a mental blueprint or "social script" of how one is supposed to act in a specific environment, governed by situational norms.

- Q: How does the "Bull in a China Shop" profile act according to the Jo-Hari Window? A: They have high self-disclosure but low feedback solicitation. They tell everyone what they think but rarely ask for or listen to feedback, making them unaware of the damage they cause.
- Q: What is the "Relationship Staircase"? A: It is a visual progression of relationship building, moving step-by-step from lower-tier engagements like a "How's Business Phone Call" up to high-tier engagements like "Dinner With Spouse" or "Movies / Ballet".
- Q: Why is starting a conversation with a "Global Reference" useful? A: It expands the "Permission Boundary" of the conversation and reduces tension by referencing an entity beyond the person you are talking to.
- Q: What are the components of Freud's Psyche Structure mentioned in the support slides? A: The Super-Ego (the strict librarian driven by morality), the Ego (the exhausted mediator driven by reality), and the Id (the spoiled toddler driven by pleasure).

6.3. Structured COI - Part 1 - The Psychology of COI

Content Covered	Why
This session begins by understanding The differences between the 3 relation types and the focus on being 'structured' (and how some may view this as being inauthentic)	This builds on what is explained in the Strategic Networking session (Strategic networking vs Centre of Influence development) by adding the Centre of Intelligence relationship. Each plays their part in developing the skills and confidence of an advisor, each provides new business opportunities.
The content proceeds to explore the You can't trust the process if you don't know how it works! 4 Processing Styles 4 Requirements for Successful Business Relationships	The Honey & Mumford processing styles makes it easy for an advisor to critique their style and 'flow-rate' of information and observe how it's received by their clients. The Advisor-e business relation requirements illustrate the 'steps' required to reduce risk and time when developing COI's.
We then explore the Expect to give before you receive 4 Referral Styles 5 Approach Options	Knowing the 4 referral styles makes it easy for an advisor to 'coach' their COI to referral opportunities that are most commonly missed and the Approach options give practical places for advisors to start,

	depending on their current skill, confidence and established networks.
Our focus then shifts to Coded Behaviour and how the Law of reciprocity drives a facade. The Psychology of the Advisor-e C.O.I Process	Advisors can waste an incredible amount of time if they are not aware of coded behaviour traits. The Advisor-e COI process provides the roadmap for COI success.
Finally, we review the Identify Your Top 3 C.O.I Targets Identify Your First 3 'Case Study' Clients	Knowledge isn't converted until action is taken.

6.3.1. Structured COI 1. Coach Prep

Benefits:

- **How it helps the business owner:** Ensures that the professional advising them has undergone rigorous, scenario-based training, leading to a more structured and authentic business relationship rather than a haphazard sales pitch.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Serves as a precise facilitation guide. It prevents the coach/advisor from going off-topic by breaking down a 1.5-hour training session into strict time slots, key discussion points, and targeted breakout questions.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** Coaches, agency managers, or senior advisors who are tasked with training teams on the fundamentals of structured COI relationship building.

How to use the material in practice (Step-by-Step):

1. **Schedule the Session:** Set aside at least 90 minutes to allow for the 47-minute video run time plus five interactive breakout sessions.
2. **Introduce Foundational Concepts:** Begin by explaining the difference between relationship types, and frame structured networking as an authentic process. Use the coaching note: "Going on a professional journey - referrals may take time but confidence... comes quickly".
3. **Run the Break-outs:** Pause at the designated time slots (e.g., 7 min 20, 18 min 26). Have the team discuss differences in relationship types, guess the processing styles of their colleagues, and share past bad referral experiences.
4. **Anchor the Process:** Ensure the team memorizes the milestone terms ("Could We... etc.") to anchor the stages of the Advisor-e COI Process in their minds.

5. **Assign Actionable Homework:** Instruct the advisors to identify 3 initial COI targets, plan their approach (phone vs. email), rehearse their preferred topic, and secure a "coffee chat" before the next session.

Common Q&A:

1. **How long is the total video run time for this Part 1 session?** 47 minutes and 53 seconds.
2. **Why is structured networking sometimes viewed negatively?** It can sometimes be viewed as being inauthentic, which is a key discussion point in the first break-out session.
3. **What is the core coaching philosophy behind "Taking Baby Steps"?** "Just start - figure the rest later! Progress - Not perfection. Remove the blockage - don't increase the pressure."
4. **What should advisors discuss during the 46 min 45 sec break-out?** They should discuss the 'back to front' philosophy of the Advisor-e process, noting their positive and negative thoughts.
5. **What are the required homework tasks for advisors after this session?** Plan their approach to 3 clients, rehearse their topic to build confidence, make contact to secure a coffee chat, and bring group feedback.

6.3.2. New COI Suppt

Benefits:

- **How it helps the business owner:** It protects the business owner from "buyer's remorse" by ensuring communication channels clearly define expectations and prioritize relationship building over aggressive technical selling. This leads to outcomes that are predictable and mutually beneficial (win-win).
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides the advisor with a psychological framework to identify a prospect's behavioral "Processing Style" (Activist, Pragmatist, Reflector, Theorist). It transitions the advisor from simply "selling" to "structured networking" by breaking down relationship building into actionable requirements: Trust, Confidence, Understanding, and Common Objectives.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** Advisors, professional service providers, or sales professionals who want to systematically build a network of referral partners (Centres of Influence) rather than relying on chance encounters.

How to use the material in practice (Step-by-Step):

1. **Differentiate your network:** Clearly identify whether the individuals in your network are existing clients, Centres of Influence (referral sources), or Centres of Intelligence (mentors/information sources).
2. **Determine their Processing Style:** When engaging with a target COI, observe how they identify information and what they seek. Classify them as an Activist, Pragmatist, Reflector,

or Theorist, and adjust your communication to avoid their specific pitfalls (e.g., Paralysis by Analysis for a Pragmatist).

3. **Establish the 4 Core Requirements:** Systematically build Trust (through firm knowledge and consistent action), Confidence (through sharing how you will deliver), Understanding (by defining expectations over technical jargon), and Common Objectives (finding the win-win).
4. **Select an Approach Strategy:** Based on your history with the contact, choose from one of the 5 approach strategies: Direct, Back Door, Indirect, Previous Dealings, or Strong Dealings.
5. **Execute the Advisor-e Process:** Progress the relationship deliberately through the four stages: "Could We" (need for discussion), "How Would We" (gaining understanding), "Will We" (identifying roadblocks), and finally, a "Test/Review" using 3 trial client cases.

Common Q&A:

1. **What is the difference between a Centre of Influence and a Centre of Intelligence?** A Centre of Influence can provide referrals and assist in securing new clients, whereas a Centre of Intelligence provides valuable information, mentorship, or operational assistance.
2. **What is the difference between networking and selling?** Networking is selling yourself, while selling is strictly selling your product or service.
3. **Why should an advisor avoid using too much technical information early on?** Detailed technical information seldom completes a sale but often prevents one because it requires the prospect to have a high level of understanding. Prospects respond better to *how* you intend to communicate and develop the relationship.
4. **What are the four Processing Styles and what is the danger of an "Activist"?** The four styles are Activist, Pragmatist, Reflector, and Theorist. If an Activist buys too quickly, they are prone to buyer's remorse, requiring you to "back-fill" their knowledge of why the purchase is sound.
5. **What is "Coded Behaviour" and why do we use it?** Coded behavior acts as "social grammar." We use it for predictability (reducing social anxiety), establishing social cohesion (signaling you belong to an "in-group"), and protecting the respect or gravity of sacred events.

6.4. Structured COI - Part 2 - Your Profile, Logistics & Solution

Content Covered	Why
This session begins by understanding the need to Start with your 'comfort range' COI profile (you should have 3 in mind already). We then discuss	Starting within a 'comfort range' allows advisors to build immediate confidence by applying skills in familiar territory, while recognizing that logistics drive success ensures they

why Logistics drive success before discussing how to start building your solution with a 3x win.	are strategically focusing their limited time on the highest-probability opportunities.
We now explore that Strategic planning is not a linear process (that's why you use scenario analysis / war games) to learn that logistics is the foundation of strategy & operations.	Moving away from linear thinking toward scenario analysis enables advisors to strategically prepare for various outcomes; this readiness, combined with overcoming perceived limitations, builds the confidence to commit the necessary resources to win.
We're starting to put some jigsaw pieces together... Now that you have awareness of your logistical assumptions - does your 'first draft' offer sound compelling enough to justify the time you're planning to invest?	You need to know that what you're offering has been critically reviewed; this allows you to sit in front of your COI and feel confident you have something worthy of their attention. This in turn, is likely to influence the energy and time you dedicate towards this component of your career development.
Our focus then shifts to <u>doing the math</u> , what's the (Time, Control, Money) benefits to Client, C.O.I (if involved), You, Your practice/team? Find the good and the bad.	Quantifying benefits through the lens of Time, Control, and Money provides a rigorous strategic framework for value; knowing the "math" behind the win-win-win gives advisors the confidence to present a compelling, balanced offer.
Finally, we review Who you 'bounce the concept' with? Who can help you shape your solution? Who can you discuss 'project progress' with?	Shifting the focus from personal performance to 'project progress' is a strategic move that utilizes a feedback loop to refine the offer; this mindset significantly boosts confidence by reducing the fear of personal judgment during implementation

6.4.1. Your Profile, Logistics & Compelling Offer Coach Prep

Benefits:

- **How it helps the business owner:** It results in an offering that focuses directly on the value the client understands and desires, rather than internal firm metrics or technical jargon.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Provides a comprehensive workshop framework for taking theoretical C.O.I concepts and grounding them in hard logistics and compelling messaging. It forces the advisor to align their personal story with their solution offer.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** Coaches or managers running the secondary ("Part 2") training sessions focused on operationalizing networking strategies, logistics, and feedback mechanics.

How to use the material in practice (Step-by-Step):

1. **Setup the 90-Minute Workshop:** Prepare for a 23 minute 11 second video interspersed with 5 interactive breakout sessions to fuel a "team feeling".
2. **Define Logistics and Limitations:** Have the team input variables into the logistics model to discuss success estimates. Challenge the group to assess whether their constraints regarding time and resources are legitimate or just perceived.
3. **Align the Solution to the Story:** Run a breakout session where advisors check their solution bullet points against their logistical capabilities. Coach them to focus *only* on what the client will value from the client's level of understanding.
4. **Model the Value Proposition:** Have participants check their solution against the "Time, Control, Money" benefits to ensure it is compelling to the client, the COI, and the advisor's practice.
5. **Establish a Feedback Routine:** Discuss who the advisors can bounce concepts off and share project progress with. Frame the feedback around the "project" rather than the person to reduce feelings of personal judgment.

Common Q&A:

1. **What is the total video run time for the Part 2 coaching session?** 23 minutes and 11 seconds.
2. **How should a coach guide an advisor struggling with the logistics phase?** Advise them to "get comfortable being uncomfortable" because it is not a linear 1-2-3 process, but rather a personal journey.
3. **Why use scenario analysis or "war games" during logistical planning?** Because strategic planning is not a linear process, and logistics forms the foundation of strategy and operations.
4. **How can advisors mitigate feelings of judgment when establishing a feedback loop?** By making the feedback about the 'project' rather than about themselves personally.
5. **What is the suggested homework for this module?** Advisors must decide who they are rehearsing with and when, and schedule a brief review to get together and share "war stories".

6.4.2. Profile, Logistics & Solution Support

Benefits:

- **How it helps the business owner:** Offers solutions focused on core emotional and operational drivers—specifically saving them time, giving them control, and making them money.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Helps the advisor eliminate wasted time by defining strict geographic, demographic, and financial parameters for ideal referral partners. It provides a mathematical logistical model to forecast exactly how many calls and meetings are required to secure a desired number of COIs.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** Professionals needing a highly structured, numbers-based approach to defining their target market, organizing their outreach funnel, and refining their core value proposition.

How to use the material in practice (Step-by-Step):

1. **Define the Ideal Profile:** Use the provided firm profiles to outline exactly who you are targeting. For example, look for accountants or lawyers with specific staff counts, within 1.5 hours driving distance, with specific client-base spreads.
2. **Match Work-Mix to Client Mix:** Use the tables to align the target firm's specializations with the types of clients you want (e.g., target corporate finance lawyers if you want to reach corporate clients).
3. **Map Out Logistics:** Input your targets into the C.O.I Logistics Model. Determine how many COIs you desire (e.g., 7) and calculate the conversion percentages across the "Could We", "How Would We", and "Will We" stages to determine your required weekly prospecting hours.
4. **Define Your Service Offer:** Write out bullet points of what you deliver (e.g., reduce write-offs, assist with leverage, increase sustainable fees).
5. **Apply the Time, Control, Money Script:** Present your service offer by explaining to the prospect that to get more free time and money out of their business, they must take control of strategic planning.

Common Q&A:

1. **What defines an ideal profile for a legal firm COI?** 2-5 Partners/Directors, 1-4 Senior Associates, 8-50 staff, commercially focused, within 1.5 hours drive, with a partner fee rate around 300–400+ per hour.
2. **If I want to reach Med-Large SMEs or High Net Worth Individuals through a lawyer, what work-mix should I look for?** You should look for lawyers specializing in Litigation/Dispute Resolution.
3. **What is the "Time, Control, Money" Script?** It is a script highlighting that the three reasons people go into business are Time, Control, and Money. It explains that businesses often take control of the owner, drain their time, and spit out no money, framing strategic planning as the solution.

4. What is the difference between a Balancing and Reinforcing feedback loop? A Balancing (Negative) feedback loop keeps things stable by pulling a system back to its goal (like a thermostat). A Reinforcing (Positive) feedback loop creates momentum by taking a small change and snowballing it (like compound interest).
5. What are the steps in the general process of meeting a COI? Choose an entity/industry, check website info, email internally for connections, ask existing clients for warm introductions, apply for membership, phone the receptionist to find a name, and then phone the individual directly.

6.5. Structured COI - Part 3 - The Event, Cause, Effect Method - Building Common Problem Stories

Content Covered	Why
This session is specifically designed for dealing with 'Mr Prickly'. We learn how the framework serves as an 'Anchor' to reduce your nerves, and establish context to aid in comprehension for everyone. We discuss why this is a Framework for Problem Solving, Not Just Selling.	Using this framework provides a reliable mental anchor that reduces performance anxiety when facing disengaged or passive-aggressive prospects ("Mr Prickly"). By positioning the interaction as a problem-solving exercise rather than a sales pitch, you separate yourself from the competition and avoid putting clients on "high-alert".
The content proceeds to explore why the reveal order & dissociation matters. We then learn how to Position with Experience & Credibility as we Achieve Congruence with Empathy. From here, you Develop Your Solutions Accordingly.	Mastering the reveal order allows you to illustrate technical expertise through 3rd-person dissociation while simultaneously building a deep emotional connection through 1st-person empathy. This dual approach ensures the client thinks, "this person gets me," which is essential for securing their trust and engagement.
We then explore the Use of a Persona to stay in 3rd person. The rule of 5 and 3 - Cause to Effect - when building your story.	Utilising personas creates a "3rd Person Perspective" that allows you to discuss sensitive issues without asking the prospect to expose a weakness, enabling them to "Save Face". Following a structured "rule of 5 and 3" helps you "slip past their filter" to explore greater detail as the client relaxes into the story.

Our focus then shifts to Genuine Observations; this lets you Speak From the Heart.	Relying on genuine observations moves you beyond a script, allowing you to create "Theatre in Their Mind" through storytelling. This increases personal relevance and emotional intensity, making your advice more memorable and impactful for the client.
Finally, we review a similar approach - (Same method in construction, with delivery in 1st person.) "Let's fix the problem - not the blame" style for problem solving.	This approach allows you to extend the engagement arena (the "Up-Sell") without appearing to "hydraulic" the client for more fees. By focusing on fixing the problem rather than the blame, you reinforce your role as a partner dedicated to better client outcomes, which leads to longer and more profitable relationships.

6.5.1. Event, Cause, Effect Method - Coach Prep

Benefits

- **How it helps the business owner:** It ensures the business owner engages with an advisor who operates with genuine congruence rather than rehearsed sales scripts. The process ensures that conversations revolve around the principle of *"Let's fix the problem - not the blame,"* generating a collaborative rather than adversarial relationship.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides the advisor with a structured 90-minute training agenda that acts as an "Anchor" to reduce their nerves. Through deliberate role-play levels, it helps advisors speak from the heart using genuine observations, while distinctly separating them from their competition.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** This document is designed for coaches, team leaders, or senior advisors facilitating a 1.5-hour group training session for financial or business advisors looking to refine their client engagement skills.

How to Use the Material in Practice (Step-by-Step)

1. **Set the Agenda:** Schedule a 1.5-hour session. Allocate roughly 33 minutes for video run time and the remaining time for five interactive breakout sessions.
2. **Discuss Benefits & Past Experiences:** Begin the breakout sessions by having participants share their past experiences dealing with a "Mr Prickly" and draw out how they felt when they were "channeled" or manipulated by leading questions in previous meetings.
3. **Explain the Objective:** Discuss the importance of achieving congruence (empathy and understanding) rather than just telling the client how capable the advisor is.

4. **Build the Stories:** Instruct participants to use the "rule of 5 and 3" (5 Causes to 3 Effects). Have them use a persona to maintain the 3rd person perspective and either edit the provided story examples or build their own from scratch.
5. **Execute Level-Based Role Play:**
 - *Level 1:* Have participants role-play with their script notes visible to adapt cadence, tone, and phraseology.
 - *Level 2:* Have participants role-play without their script notes.
 - *Level 3:* Introduce the adversarial element where the person playing the client becomes testing, unresponsive, or acts like "Mr Prickly".
6. **Assign Homework:** Instruct the advisors to organize "free-sparring" (like martial artists) with a partner outside of the session and set a date to regroup and share "war stories".

Common Q&A Derived from This Document

1. **Q: How much time should be allocated for a coaching session on this method?**
 - **A:** The session requires at least 90 minutes (1.5 hours) to accommodate 33 minutes of video runtime and five interactive breakout sessions.
2. **Q: What is the underlying theory that separates this framework from the competition?**
 - **A:** It relies on Dan Sperber's argumentative theory, utilizing a framework designed for problem-solving rather than just selling.
3. **Q: What is the focus of the "Building Your Common Problem Stories" breakout?**
 - **A:** Advisors discuss the Causes and Effects in the provided story example, edit them for relevance, and prepare for their first run-through using the rule of 5 and 3.
4. **Q: How does the role-play difficulty scale during the coaching session?**
 - **A:** It starts at Level 1 with scripts visible to practice tone, moves to Level 2 without scripts, and advances to Level 3 where the 'client' becomes adversarial and testing.
5. **Q: What is the recommended mindset for practicing the "Up-Sell" (Look Both Ways)?**
 - **A:** It uses the exact same method construction delivered in the 1st person, rooted in the philosophy of *"Let's fix the problem - not the blame"*.
6. **Q: What is "Free-Sparring" in the context of this training?**
 - **A:** It is the homework phase where advisors rehearse their scripts without notes, mimicking how martial artists practice technique in preparation for actual combat.

6.5.2. Event, Cause, Effect Method - Support Slides

Benefits

- **How it helps the business owner:** It allows the business owner to "Save Face" by exploring common industry issues without forcing them to expose their own weaknesses. It prevents them from feeling manipulated or "Channeled" by leading questions, and reduces the stress of a standard sales encounter, which often puts clients on "high-alert".
- **How it helps the advisor:** The framework serves as a mental anchor to keep the advisor on track. It helps the advisor establish credibility and empathy simultaneously, allowing them to pre-empt objections ("Call the Ghosts") without engaging in an argumentative conflict. It also helps advisors build emotional connections ("Theatre in Their Mind") rather than just resorting to up-selling or over-selling.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** This material is highly suitable for advisors dealing with passive-aggressive, unresponsive, or disengaged prospects (personified in the text as "Mr Prickly").

How to Use the Material in Practice (Step-by-Step)

1. **Introduce the Event:** Start with an "Event" to capture the prospect's attention and intrigue. For example, mention a scenario like a business owner dealing with short-term cash flow issues.
2. **Reveal the Causes (3rd Person):** Share up to five (5) "Causes" to illustrate your technical expertise and experience. Deliver this step entirely in the 3rd person (e.g., *"They struggle with... Their issue is..."*) to create dissociation and avoid making the prospect defensive.
3. **Explain the Effects (1st Person):** Detail up to three (3) "Effects" to forge an emotional connection and achieve congruence. Deliver this step "in character" using the 1st person, shifting your tone and cadence so the prospect knows you are acting. This evoking a response where the prospect feels *"this person gets me"*.
4. **Practice Constructing Stories:** Build your own stories by mapping symptoms to underlying drivers (Causes) and outlining how those symptoms are commonly articulated by frustrated owners (Effects).
5. **Look Both Ways (Extend the Engagement):** Analyze the "Pre/Cause" and "Post/Effect" environments to find practical next steps for the client. This might include examining their chart of accounts, utilizing a Revenue Model to identify how to pay back a loan faster, or establishing new management KPIs.
6. **Role Play:** Practice the structure in pairs or threes. Focus on following the construction correctly rather than being "script perfect".

Common Q&A Derived from This Document

1. Q: Why shouldn't an advisor use standard sales questions like, "Tell me what keeps you awake at night"?
 - o A: Standard sales approaches place both parties in an "arena of conflict," which triggers evolutionary survival responses and puts the client on "high-alert".
 2. Q: What is the primary psychological advantage of discussing "Common Problems"?
 - o A: It uses a 3rd Person Perspective to create a safe distance between the advisor, the client, and the problem, making it much easier to find common ground without making the client feel exposed.
 3. Q: How does the framework help you handle a "Mr Prickly" client?
 - o A: By stopping successive leading questions, it reduces the client's feeling of being manipulated or "channeled" into an outcome, which affirms their trust and confidence in the advisor.
 4. Q: During the delivery of the framework, how exactly should the 'Effects' be presented?
 - o A: They should be delivered "in character" using 1st person phrasing, shifting tone and cadence to create "theatre in their mind" and evoke an emotional response.
 5. Q: Is the goal of "Looking Both Ways" to maximize fee extraction from the client?
 - o A: No. The text specifically states it is *not* about up-selling, over-selling, or "Hydraulicizing" the client for greater fees; it is purely about doing the job properly to ensure better client outcomes.
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6.6. Fee Estimate & Job Creep Discussions

Content Covered	Why
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The 2 Scenarios That 'Sneak Up' On You.	It's important to begin by identifying the subtle differences between the two scenarios and then categorise them for future reference. This aids in learning and retention (we want to make the content 'sticky'!)
Why Professionals Avoid Fee Discussions	It's vital that advisors understand the emotional drivers that surround this topic, so they can make a conscious decision to better prepare and better cope with these scenarios in future.
Scenario 1: Prime & Range-Link	This section explores the process of priming and explains WHY it's the critical first step in coping with the identified scenario.
Scenario 1: Blow-out (2nd Prime) & Evidence	This section explores the second half of scenario 1 and the suggested actions to take.
Scenario 2:	This last section explores the second (identified) scenario and outlines the philosophy required to make the approach successful.

6.6.1. Fee Estimate & Job Creep Coach Prep

Benefits:

- **How it helps the business owner:** It provides a structured 90-minute training agenda to cultivate a team capable of handling difficult fee discussions and managing job creep, ultimately protecting the firm's profitability and fostering a unified "team feeling". It also enforces accountability by assigning specific homework tasks to ensure the team practices the skills learned.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It equips advisors with psychological tools to understand when the "balance of power" shifts and gives them practical frameworks, such as using the "magic word" 'because' to logically justify their pricing. It also reduces their anxiety by encouraging "free-sparring" (role-playing) in a safe environment before facing real clients.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** Coaches, team leaders, or managers tasked with training professional advisory teams on client communication, boundary setting, and fee estimation.

How to use the material in practice (Step-by-Step):

1. **Schedule the Session:** Allocate at least 90 minutes for the training session to accommodate the 30-minute and 52-second video run time and allow ample time for five distinct break-out sessions.

2. **Identify the Threat:** Introduce the "2 Scenarios That 'Sneak Up' On You" ("How much for this little job?" and the "Assumed Close"). Have the team brainstorm how to 'label' these scenarios so they can easily identify them in the future and know how to react.
3. **Analyze Avoidance & Power Dynamics:** Discuss why professionals avoid fee discussions. Prompt the team to identify which type of client they feel comfortable standing up to and discuss where the "balance of power" shifts during these interactions.
4. **Teach Scenario 1 Tactics:** Introduce the "Prime & Range-Link" concept. Instruct advisors to use the word "because" when giving price ranges, as it shows their logic and provides "proof" to support their beliefs. Have the team brainstorm prompt lines.
5. **Implement the Blow-out Warning:** Teach the team to make the client "own the problem" by using a blow-out warning and providing evidence in their advice. Discuss the consequences of failing to explain these warnings.
6. **Teach Scenario 2 Tactics:** Introduce the "Old Car Maintenance" philosophy for handling 'Assumed Close' situations. Brainstorm prompt lines and practice them.
7. **Assign Homework:** Conclude the session by having advisors schedule "free-sparring" (role-play) sessions with colleagues and set a date for a brief review to share "war stories".

Common Q&A derived from this document:

1. **Q:** How much time should be allocated for a coaching session using this material? **A:** At least 90 minutes should be allowed to ensure the 1.5-hour session fuels interaction and accommodates the video and five break-out sessions.
 2. **Q:** What are the two main scenarios that 'sneak up' on professionals? **A:** The first is when a client asks, "How much for this little job?" and the second is when a client hits the advisor with an 'Assumed Close'.
 3. **Q:** Why is the word "because" referred to as a "magic word"? **A:** If you want to know what someone believes about something causal or related, listen for "because"; it reveals the logic or 'proof' supporting their pricing and association.
 4. **Q:** What is the purpose of the "Blow-out warning"? **A:** It forces the client to own the problem, acting as a defensible position alongside providing evidence in the advice, rather than just on the invoice.
 5. **Q:** How should advisors prepare for these difficult conversations after the session? **A:** They should engage in "free-sparring," which is how martial artists practice technique ready for combat; role-play is no different.
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6.6.2. Fee Estimate & Job Creep Support

Benefits:

- **How it helps the business owner:** It provides a comprehensive set of tutorial visual aids and "cheat sheets" that standardise the firm's responses to tricky client behaviors, specifically detailing how to handle "Cheap Skates" and "Freeloaders".
- **How it helps the advisor:** It offers deep psychological insights into "Coded Behavior" and Freud's Psyche Structure, helping advisors understand the root causes of their own "imposter syndrome" and burnout. It also arms them with literal scripts they can memorize to maintain control during fee discussions.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** Professional advisors facing high-pressure environments who need both practical scripts to handle job creep and a psychological framework to protect their professional self-image.

How to use the material in practice (Step-by-Step):

1. **Define the Scenarios:** Start by formally defining the two problematic client scenarios: Scenario 1 involves a client who downplays a task to influence the price estimate, while Scenario 2 involves a client using an 'assumed close' to avoid the topic of fees entirely.
2. **Explain Coded Behavior:** Use the concepts of Erving Goffman to explain "Coded Behavior." Compare attending a funeral versus a wedding to show how social scripts govern norms, reduce social anxiety, and signal social cohesion.
3. **Address the Professional Psyche:** Review Freud's Psyche Structure (Super-Ego, Ego, Id) to explain the "Professional Self Image Quandary". Discuss how an overly dominant Super-Ego (the 'Internal CEO') demands perfectionism, turning the advisor into a "Social Chameleon" and leading to burnout.
4. **Deploy Scenario 1 Scripts:** Provide the team with Priming Scripts (e.g., "We've been seeing a lot of this lately...") to subtly message clients that their problem is common or urgent. Practice the "Price Range Script" linking the estimate to complex variables using the word "BECAUSE".
5. **Utilize Blow-Out and Evidence Scripts:** Instruct the team to use the Blow-out script ("that may not be the maximum price - BUT - if we do need to go higher, we'll stop...") and the Evidence script to maintain a defensible position.
6. **Deploy Scenario 2 Scripts:** Use the "Old Car Maintenance Philosophy" for assumed closes. Teach scripts like, "I'll run that past 'name' and get back to you with a fee estimate, so you can decide if it's worth spending the time on, or not".
7. **Review the Cheat Sheet:** Use the "Practice (Cheat Sheet) Example" to drill the distinct approaches needed when facing a 'Cheap Skate' versus a 'Freeloader'.

Common Q&A derived from this document:

1. **Q:** How does Scenario 1 differ from Scenario 2? **A:** In Scenario 1, the client wants a price estimate but attempts to 'downplay' the engagement to influence it; in Scenario 2, the client adopts an 'assumed close' to avoid raising the issue of price at all.
2. **Q:** What is "Coded Behavior" according to social psychology? **A:** It is behavior that follows a "social script"—a mental blueprint governed by situational norms, acting as a "social grammar" that allows us to communicate complex emotions without saying a single word.
3. **Q:** What causes burnout according to the "Psycho-babble" notes? **A:** Burnout occurs when the Super-Ego becomes overly dominant, demanding an internalised ideal of competence; the Ego becomes a mere servant to the impossible standard of 'The Perfect Employee,' unable to mediate the Id's exhaustion.
4. **Q:** How should an advisor phrase a price estimate to account for unknown variables? **A:** "Off the top of my head I'd estimate somewhere between X and Y - BECAUSE - we need to consider A,B and C before we draw a conclusion...".
5. **Q:** What is an example script using the "Old Car Maintenance Philosophy"? **A:** "We've got someone in the office who specialises in that, I'll get them to take a quick look at your situation and put together a fee estimate so you can decide if you want us to go ahead, or not.".